Research Statement

Filipa Calado

This statement covers my research agenda, recent papers, and future plans since beginning my position at the Pratt Institute School of Information in Fall 2024.

Research Agenda

I am a language scholar that uses digital tools to study language related to gender, sex, and sexuality. While my formal training is in English literature, with focuses in queer studies and the digital humanities (DH), I work at the intersection of the humanities and computer science (CS) disciplines, and aim my research toward audiences in AI ethics, computational linguistics, queer studies, trans studies, and DH-related fields.

To that end, I pursue a research agenda based on three main goals:

1. to interrogate the contradictions of present-day theorizations of gender, sex, and sexuality;
2. to read computational mechanisms and their effect on language meaning; and
3. to communicate to audiences across humanities and CS disciplines.

From Fall 2024 to Fall 2026, I have written five papers, two that have been published in peer-reviewed venues, and three that are currently being considered for publication at peer-reviewed venues. In addition, I am also completing a manuscript for an academic book, which is due in spring 2027.

In what follows, I explain the details of my research work and how they fit into the goals described above.

Goal #1: to interrogate the contradictions of present-day theorizations of gender, sex, and sexuality

Over the past decade, the discourse around gender, sex, and sexuality has been highly polarized around positions like the "anti-gender movement," "gender-critical feminism" and "Trans Exclusionary Radical Feminism" (TERFism), which have moved into the mainstream.[1] These largely reactionary movements are driven by resistance against so-called "gender ideology" and, in response, seek to ground gender in "the biological reality of sex."[2]

I approach these contemporary discourses on gender, sex, and sexuality as an information scholar interested in how categories and representations are encoded and operationalized in datasets, computational systems, media, and other information infrastructures. Taking

[1] Bassi, Serena; LaFleur, Greta (2022). "Introduction: TERFs, Gender-Critical Movements, and Postfascist Feminisms". Transgender Studies Quarterly. 9 (3): 311–333. https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-9836008

[2] The White House. "Defending Women From Gender Ideology Extremism And Restoring Biological Truth To The Federal Government." The White House, January 21, 2025.

these contemporary discourses on gender, sex, and sexuality as a starting point, my research interrogates and disentangles some of the contradictions that constitute social and cultural understanding of these terms through computational analysis. This work aims not only to parse out ideological investments and contradictions among these terms, but also to surface areas of potential overlap and unexpected consensus between polarized views.

In two recent papers, both of which are currently being considered at peer-reviewed venues, I explore how trans studies theorizing of gender as an expressive, material, and behavioral phenomenon opens a potential site of alignment between ideological perspectives on gender. The first paper, "What LLMs Can't See About Gender," under review at *FAccT 2027*, discusses the topic of gender bias in Large Language Model (LLM) evaluation methods. This method draws from recent theorizing in trans studies to show how current methods in language modeling limit the ability to detect, or *see*, gender as an identity that operates visibly in the world. The second paper, "'My Body Feels Like it's Coming Off': on Cis Embodiment in *Love Is Blind*," under review at *TSQ: Trans Studies Quarterly*, reads experiences of bodily dissonance in a reality TV dating show that features cisgender and heterosexual participants. The paper argues that, despite their dramatically different self-identifications and life experiences, trans and cis-hetero subjects have similar experiences in how they relate to their own bodies and, in some cases, how they desire normativity.

Goal #2: to read computational mechanisms and their effect on language meaning

This research goal is main goal of my book, *Queer Code: Re-working Language Technologies*, which is under contract with Bloomsbury Academic Press. The book explores how language technologies, like web scraping, text analysis, and generative AI, reduce language complexity to make it manageable and computable at large scales. These increasingly automated processes encode dominant logics and extractive incentives onto language data, creating well-documented issues with data sovereignty, privacy, and most recently, social bias and discrimination, as current AI tools demonstrate.

The book demonstrates how to re-work technological processes that constrain or reduce language meaning by looking to queer studies concepts that resist oppressive structures from within. Drawing from concepts like Judith Butler's Gender Performativity and José Esteban Muñoz's theory of Dis-Identification, for example, the book re-works constraining computational mechanisms into new analytical methodologies that open up novel readings of language data.

The table below outlines the book's five body chapters, mapping the chapter's topic with the technology under analysis and the relevant analytic from queer studies.

Chapter Title	Technology	Queer Studies Concept
1. Text Capture	Web Scraping	Paranoid Reading[3]
2. Text Analysis	Text Analysis	Gender Performativity[4]
3. Text Preservation	Markup Languages	Dis-Identification[5]
4. Text Display	Screen Display and Animation	The Flesh[6]
5. Text Generation	Machine Learning	Body Dysphoria[7]

Goal #3: communicating to audiences across humanities and CS disciplines

My research aims to engage knowledges that otherwise may not come into contact with one another. Over the past two years, I have written three papers for fields like computational linguistics, AI ethics, trans studies, and digital scholarly editing, which span humanities and CS disciplines.

My CS papers include "Some Myths About Bias: A Queer Studies Reading Of Gender Bias In NLP," published in the *Association for Computational Linguistics Proceedings* in August 2025, "Small Language Models and the Synthetic Middle," currently under review at *FAccT 2027*, and the aforementioned "What LLMs Can't See About Gender," also under review at *FAccT 2027*. These papers draw from theorizing in queer studies and trans studies in order to make recommendations to CS fields. "Some Myths About Bias" argues that queer studies theorizing on the binary reveals certain traps of "binary thinking" that drive bias detection and mitigation techniques in Natural Language Processing (NLP). The other paper, "Small Language Models and the Synthetic Middle," incorporate the humanistic method of close reading into a computational experiment to study linguistic overlaps (the "synthetic middle") between polarized discourses on gender and transgender rights in the USA.

On the side of the humanities, my papers include "Re-encoding Dominance: Queer Approaches To TEI Markup," published in *Digital Editing & Publishing in the 21st Century* in April 2025. This paper examines how a language technology, TEI (Text Encoding Initiative), a markup standard for encoding text-based cultural heritage materials into preservable formats, alongside theories from queer studies. Much like my work on the *Queer Code* book, the goal of this paper is to read technical mechanism as a heuristic for how power operates in social and cultural norms—in this case, that data formats disambiguate data into modular components in ways that delimit what said.

Future Plans

My most immediate plan is to continue my work on the *Queer Code* book, which is due (in manuscript) on March 31, 2027.

I also intend to explore the issue of ideological polarization around gender in a more sustained way, perhaps in a subsequent book devoted primiarily to that topic. Moving beyond my work in *Queer Code*, which draws in part from my doctoral disseration in literary studies, I see myself focusing on language in contemporary and popular discourses, such as popular journalism and reality TV, as my most recent work demonstrates. Given my background and training, I feel an urgency to apply literary and queer studies

[3]Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading; or, you're so Paranoid, you Probably Think this Introduction is about you." *Novel Gazing: Queer Readings in Fiction* (1997): 1-37.

[4]Butler, Judith. *Bodies That Matter: on the Discursive Limits of Sex*. Routledge, 2011.

[5]Muñoz, José Esteban. *Disidentifications: Queers of Color and the Performance of Politics*. Vol. 2. U of Minnesota Press, 2013.

[6]Spillers, Hortense J. "Mama's Baby, Papa's Maybe: An American Grammar Book." *Diacritics* 17, no. 2 (1987): 65-81.

[7]Prosser, Jay. *Second Skins: The Body Narratives of Transsexuality*. Columbia University Press, 1998. Prosser, Jay.

frameworks toward analyzing ideologically-encoded discourses that proliferate increasingly across information networks.

Finally, it is important to my values as a scholar and educator that I continue to make this research legible across disciplines and fields. In light of that, I will continue to publish in CS and humanities venues, rather than committing to one or the other, with the goal of publishing one peer-reviewed article per year in each of these areas.